The Problem Neighbour

In 1968, Czechoslovakia became a unique communist oasis of freedom when Alexander Dubček attempted to bring democratic change to the country, promising ‘socialism with a human face’ by the ‘widest possible democratisation’, the correction of past mistakes and the rehabilitation of victims persecuted during the Stalinist era.

In this excited atmosphere, it was hardly surprising events in Prague were followed by disquiet in Moscow, where there were fears the reforms would weaken the communist bloc. The situation worsened when Dubček removed media censorship, allowing newspapers to criticise high-ranking officials and call for multi-party democracy– for Brezhnev, it was all too much.

To placate the Soviet leader, Dubček – who was by now reaching new heights of fame and reputation in the West – reaffirmed his support for the alliance with the USSR. But as spring turned to summer, Czechs continued to enjoy the freedom of expression unprecedented in the Eastern bloc. In East Berlin, Ulbricht declared Dubček’s reforms as counter-revolutionary and warned of possible ‘contagion’ to other socialist countries if not nipped in the bud. At the same time, he complained of Czechoslovakia’s increasing ties with West Germany. Sensing the brewing storm, Honecker chipped in his thoughts at the sixth session of the Central Committee in June with a speech emphasising the Party’s role as the guiding force in social progress:

The dictatorship of the proletariat has been equated with erroneous leadership methods, with violations of democracy and legality, and with other subjectively grounded errors. But this is turning things completely upside down. We will not permit the central principle of our ideology to be watered